HelpLift

User Manual

Giving made transparent. Impact made real.

A guide for givers, organizations and administrators. For quick answers at any time, ask Lifty, the assistant in the corner of every HelpLift page. Version 2026.

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CHAPTER 1

Welcome to HelpLift

HelpLift connects verified organizations that have community needs with givers who want to help. This manual explains how to use every part of the platform.

HelpLift is a South African giving platform. Verified organizations, such as schools, charities, non-profit organizations and community groups, post the needs they have. Individuals, businesses and groups help them by offering goods or services, by donating money, or by pledging gifts to the Gift Library. HelpLift administrators review activity on the platform so that everything you see can be trusted.

Who uses HelpLift

- Givers: individuals, businesses or groups that give. Givers must be 18 or older.
- Organizations: schools, charities and community groups that receive support. An organization can have a team of people with different roles.
- Administrators: the HelpLift team, who verify organizations, review needs and payments, and keep the platform safe.

How to use this manual

Chapters 2 to 4 cover what everyone needs: creating an account, signing in and finding your way around. Chapter 5 is for givers and chapter 6 is for organizations. Later chapters explain settings, accessibility, safety and where to get help.

HelpLift is free to use. Organizations and givers never pay a fee to use the platform.

CHAPTER 2

Creating an account and signing in

Registering

1. Open the HelpLift website and choose Join the Platform, or go to the Register page.
2. Choose I want to give to register as a giver, or I'm an organization to register an organization.
3. Agree to the Terms of Service and the Privacy Policy. Givers also confirm that they are 18 or older.
4. Fill in the form and choose a password. The checklist under the password shows the rules it must meet.
5. Select Create Account. HelpLift sends a verification email to the address you entered.
6. Open the email and select the link to verify your address. You can then sign in.

Givers enter their name, email address, phone number, account type (individual, business or group) and, optionally, the categories and locations they care about. These preferences are used to recommend needs to you. You can also add a display picture.

Organizations enter the organization's name, registration number, type, address, province and city, a contact person, an email address and, optionally, a mission statement, banking details and a logo. Organizations can also attach verification documents such as a registration certificate, tax exemption certificate or proof of banking. Documents can be PDF, PNG or JPG files, up to 10 files of 10 MB each.

Pictures and logos can be PNG, JPG or WebP images of up to 2 MB. You can add or change them later from your dashboard.

Verifying your email with a code

If your verification email contains a code, you can also enter it on the Verification page, together with your email address. This is useful when the link opens on a different device.

Signing in

- Email and password: enter them on the Sign In page.
- Google, LinkedIn or Microsoft: once you have registered, you can sign in with one of these accounts if it uses the same email address. They cannot be used to create a new account.
- Passkey: sign in with your fingerprint, face or device PIN. Add a passkey first in Settings while you are signed in.

Two-factor sign-in

If you turn on two-factor sign-in in Settings, HelpLift emails you a code each time you sign in with your password. Enter the code to finish signing in. You can ask for a new code if it does not arrive.

Locked account

After five wrong password attempts your account is locked to protect it. HelpLift emails you an unlock code. Enter the code to unlock the account, then sign in again.

Forgotten password

Select Forgot password on the Sign In page and enter your email address. Follow the link in the email to choose a new password.

Organization verification

A new organization is reviewed by an administrator before it can use the platform. Until then, signing in shows the Pending Verification page with the current status: pending, approved, rejected or more information requested. If more information is requested, the organization's owner can upload extra documents on that page and submit them for review.

CHAPTER 3

Finding your way around

The homepage

- Platform numbers: verified organizations, givers, open and fulfilled needs, money donated and impact stories.
- How it works: a short overview of the Gift Library, verification, dashboards and matching.
- Urgent needs: a few community requests that need support now.
- Needs map: every pin is an open need. Select a pin to see the need on the Needs board.
- Live activity: recent, anonymous activity on the platform.
- Spotlight: the Giver of the Month and the Organization of the Month.
- Impact stories: real results shared by organizations. Use the arrows to move between stories, or select Read full story.
- Questions and contact: frequently asked questions, a search box, and a contact form.

On a phone, the menu button at the top right opens the page links and the Sign In or Register buttons.

The Needs board

The Needs board lists open needs from verified organizations. You can search by keyword, filter by category, urgency or location, and sort the results. Turn on Needs near me to see needs close to you. Each need shows its organization, category, location, quantity, due date and urgency. You can listen to a need being read aloud, share it, or show its QR code. Select Support this Need to offer help or donate.

Organizations

The Organizations directory lists verified organizations. Filter by province or by organizations near you, and sort by open needs or newest. An organization's public profile shows its details, mission, timeline of updates, events and news, open needs and impact stories. Each card in the directory shows the organization's latest post. Signed-in users can send the organization a message.

The Gift Library

The Gift Library lists goods, services and funds that givers have pledged before a specific need exists. Organizations can claim offerings that would help them. Each offering is approved by an administrator before it appears.

Developers page

The Developers page explains how HelpLift is built and has a form for reporting a bug, suggesting an improvement or reporting a security issue. Reports can be anonymous. Leave a contact email if you would like a reply.

CHAPTER 4

Your dashboard

Givers, organizations and administrators each have a dashboard. The parts described in this chapter are the same on all of them.

The top of the dashboard

- Search (on a computer): find any section, action or setting on the dashboard. See Search below.
- Greeting and clock: a greeting for the time of day, with the time and date. The clock can be hidden in Settings, under User interface.
- Main actions and places come first, such as Pledge a Gift, Public Profile, Documents, Badges and Organizations, then Support The Platform and Message Admin.
- Then the round icon buttons: Feedback, Notifications (the bell), Refresh (loads the latest information without losing your filters), Theme (light, dark, high contrast or grayscale) and Home.
- Settings, and Sign out at the far right.

Icons move gently when you point at them. On the dashboard, the icons in the top buttons also give a little wiggle when you select them. Turn on Reduce motion, under Settings and Accessibility, to keep everything still.

On a phone, the buttons at the top form one toolbar of icons across the screen. Below it, small chips show what is waiting for you, such as 2 pending interests. Tap a chip to open that section. When nothing is waiting, a single line says you are all caught up.

Search

On a computer, the search box at the top left of every dashboard finds anything on it: sections such as Wallet or Timeline, actions such as Pledge a Gift or Message Admin, and settings such as Change password or Font size. It also finds things inside other screens, such as banking details in the Wallet, or each Platform settings field for administrators, and takes you straight to them. Type, or select the microphone and say what you are looking for, then choose a result. Press Ctrl and K, or the / key, to jump to the search box from anywhere on the page.

Tabs

Each dashboard is divided into tabs, such as Needs, Messages and Analytics. Select a tab to open it.

On a phone, the tabs move to a bar at the bottom of the screen with the four sections you use most. Select More to see every other section, as well as quick actions such as Badges, Message Admin and Pledge a Gift. The name of the section you are in is shown above its content. Filters that would not fit on a small screen, such as categories and statuses, become a single dropdown.

Notifications

The Notifications window lists new messages, offers, donations, approvals and announcements. Unread items are highlighted. Switch between All and Unread, select a notification to open it, or select Mark all as read. Notifications are also emailed to you unless you turn email notifications off in Settings.

You are also told when a need changes. Organizations are notified when an administrator approves, rejects, reopens, closes, marks fulfilled or removes one of their needs, and when a need closes after its due date. Givers who offered to help with a need, or donated to it, are notified when it is fulfilled, closed or removed. Administrators are notified when an organization closes a need, marks it fulfilled or asks to reopen it.

Messages

The Messages tab holds your conversations with givers, organizations and the HelpLift team. Open a message to read it and reply. You can attach files and switch between your inbox and sent messages. Coordinators can message givers the organization works with and the HelpLift team, and reply to anyone, but only owners and managers can message other organizations.

Windows

Many actions open in a window. The button next to the close button maximizes a window to fill the screen, and selecting it again restores the normal size. When one window was opened from another, a Back link at the top returns you to the first one.

Badges

Badges celebrate milestones, such as your first donation or a number of needs fulfilled. The Badges window shows the badges you have earned, your progress towards the next one, and leaderboards of top givers and organizations. You can share a badge you have earned.

Feedback and Support The Platform

Feedback lets you rate HelpLift and suggest improvements. Support The Platform lets you make a donation to HelpLift itself, which keeps the platform free. These donations do not go to any organization.

The welcome tour

The first time you open your dashboard, a short tour points out the most important parts, including the search box on a computer and the section bar on a phone. You can skip it at any time.

CHAPTER 5

For givers

Finding needs

The Browse Needs tab recommends needs that match the categories and locations you chose. You can also switch on needs near you, or open the full Needs board.

Offering to help

1. Open a need and select Support this Need.
2. Choose Submit Expression of Interest and write a short message to the organization.
3. The organization accepts or declines your offer. You are notified either way.
4. Track your offers in the My Interests tab.

When an offer is accepted it becomes a fulfillment. The Fulfillments tab shows each delivery from in progress to completed, including any proof photos the organization uploads.

Donating money

You can donate to a specific need, to an organization, or to HelpLift itself. Choose how to pay:

- EFT (bank transfer): transfer the money to the bank account shown, then upload your proof of payment. An administrator confirms the donation.
- PayFast: pay by card or instant EFT. The donation is confirmed automatically.
- PayPal: the option for international payments. PayPal charges in US dollars, converted from the Rand amount at the day's exchange rate. The donation is confirmed automatically.

The smallest and largest amounts you can donate are shown in the form. When a donation is confirmed, a PDF receipt is emailed to you. The My Donations tab shows every donation with its status, your proof of payment and your receipts, and lets you add more proof.

Pledging to the Gift Library

1. Open the Gift Library tab and select Pledge an Offering.
2. Describe what you are offering: goods, a service or funds, with the quantity or value, your location and any conditions.
3. Or select Snap to pledge and take or choose a photo of the items. The photo is analysed by AI and the form is filled in for you to check.
4. Submit the pledge. It appears in the Gift Library once an administrator approves it.

When an organization claims your offering and the claim is approved, you are notified and the delivery is tracked under Fulfillments.

If you set an expiry date, the offering is listed up to and including that date. After it, the offering comes off the Gift Library, can no longer be claimed, and you are notified. You can pledge it again at any time. Money never expires: donations and financial pledges have no expiry date.

Your profile

Select your profile picture to upload a new one or remove it. Use Settings to edit your details. If you are chosen as Giver of the Month, your name and picture appear on the homepage. You can opt out of this in Settings.

Analytics

The Analytics tab charts your giving over time. Charts can be exported.

CHAPTER 6

For organizations

Team roles

- Owner: full access, including the team, the organization's profile, banking details and withdrawals.
- Manager: creates, edits and closes needs, accepts or declines offers, claims from the Gift Library, handles deliveries, impact stories and messages, and can see donations and the wallet.
- Coordinator: handles the day-to-day work with givers. Updates deliveries and uploads proof, sends and replies to messages, and creates and edits impact stories, which an administrator still approves. Coordinators can see needs and offers but cannot change them, and never see donations, the wallet or banking details.

Owners invite teammates by email from the Team tab and choose their role.

Posting a need

1. Open the Needs tab and fill in the Create a need form: title, description, category, location, quantity, due date and urgency.
2. To save time, select Let Lifty write it, describe the need in a sentence (typed or spoken), and select Write it for me. Check and edit everything before you submit.
3. Add attachments or images if they help.
4. Submit the need. An administrator reviews it before it is published.

HelpLift warns you if a new need looks like one you have already posted. A need can be edited while it is active, but not once it is fulfilled or closed. You can mark a need as fulfilled or close it. To reopen a closed need, request a reopen with a reason, and an administrator decides.

Due dates

A need stays on the Needs board up to and including its due date. From the next day it is no longer listed and cannot receive offers or donations. If the need is still open, it is closed automatically and you are notified. To carry on, request a reopen and choose a new due date. Needs that are already in progress are not closed, so deliveries under way can finish. Donations you have already received are not affected.

Offers and deliveries

Offers from givers appear in the Interests tab, where you accept or decline them. Accepted offers and approved Gift Library claims become fulfillments. In the Fulfillments tab, track each delivery and upload proof, such as photos, receipts or documents, once items arrive. The giver is notified.

Donations and the wallet

The Donations tab lists donations received. The Wallet tab shows your available balance and withdrawal history. Only the owner can add banking details and request a withdrawal. Each withdrawal is reviewed by an administrator, within the limits shown, and proof of payment is attached once the money is paid.

Your timeline

The Timeline tab is your organization's public news feed. Post an update, an event, a milestone or news, with a title, your text, and photos or documents attached. For an event, add the date, time and location. Posts appear straight away on your public profile and on your card in the Organizations directory. No administrator approval is needed.

- Coordinators, managers and owners can post. Coordinators can edit or delete their own posts.
- Managers and owners can edit or delete any post, and pin important posts to the top.
- Every post shows when it was posted and whether it was edited, and can be shared or read aloud.

Impact stories

Share what your organization has achieved in the Impact Stories tab, with photos or videos. Stories are published on your public profile and on the homepage after an administrator approves them, and they can be shared.

Claiming from the Gift Library

In the Gift Library tab, browse offerings from givers and select Claim Offering for those that would help you. You can have one pending claim per offering. An administrator approves one claim per offering.

Profile, documents and sharing

The buttons at the top of your dashboard open your Public Profile, your verification documents and a QR code for your profile that you can share or print. Verified organizations can download a compliance certificate as proof of verification for funders and partners.

Analytics

The Analytics tab shows your needs, donations and engagement. Charts can be exported as CSV files or images.

CHAPTER 7

For administrators

Administrator accounts are created by invitation only. This chapter summarizes the administrator dashboard.

- Users: verify new organizations and their documents, view givers and administrators, edit account details, suspend accounts and invite administrators.
- Needs: approve or reject new needs, decide on reopen requests, and close a live need (for example after a tip-off), with an optional reason for the organization.
- Organizations: approve, reject or ask for more information, revoke the verification of an approved organization, or reconsider a rejected one. An organization with no donations or withdrawals can be deleted permanently, together with its team accounts.
- Timelines: remove any organization's timeline post if needed.
- Gift Library and deliveries: remove a listed offering (paid financial pledges stay listed), cancel a stuck delivery or mark one completed. The people involved are always told why.
- Needs, Gift Library, Donations, Fulfillments and Withdrawals: review and approve activity, confirm EFT donations and attach proof of payouts.
- Stories: approve impact stories before they are published.
- Messages, Feedback and Dev reports: answer users, read ratings and handle reports sent from the Developers page.
- Inquiries: anonymous tip-offs about organizations, with evidence, an investigation status and private notes, and messages sent with the homepage contact form.
- Live activity and Security: see who is online, what signed-in users are doing, and every sign-in attempt. Both logs can be filtered by date and time, and cleared when needed.
- Reports: totals, site visits and charts, with exports.
- Announcements: send messages in-app and by email, or as a login page banner or homepage notice.
- Platform settings: maintenance mode, HelpLift's bank accounts, need categories, donation and withdrawal limits, and badge thresholds.

Financial records such as donations and withdrawals can never be deleted, and administrators cannot change an organization's banking details.

CHAPTER 8

Settings

Open Settings from the gear button at the top of your dashboard.

- Edit profile: your details, contact information, login email and password.
- Passkeys: add or remove passkeys for signing in with your fingerprint, face or device PIN.
- Two-factor sign-in: an emailed code each time you sign in with your password.
- Notification sounds: turn them on or off and choose a sound.
- Email notifications: when off, notifications still appear in HelpLift but are not emailed. Account emails, such as verification and password reset, are always sent.
- Hey Lifty: open Lifty hands-free by saying Hey Lifty. It is off until you turn it on, and works in Chrome and Edge.
- User interface: select Open to choose your dashboard's colour scheme (Default, Forest, Sunset or Midnight, each a complete new look in light and dark mode), turn Lifty on or off, and show or hide the clock and date.
- Accessibility: select Open to change Font size (makes text larger across the site), Reduce motion (turns off animations) and Click sounds (soft sounds when you select buttons, tabs and switches).
- Giver of the Month (givers): opt in or out of being featured.
- User manual: download this manual.
- Delete account: permanently deletes your account. This cannot be undone.

Your colour scheme, font size, Lifty, clock, click sounds and reduce motion are saved on the device you are using. A colour scheme restyles the whole dashboard, including backgrounds, surfaces and accents; success, warning and danger colours keep their meaning. The theme is changed with the theme button at the top of the page.

CHAPTER 9

Lifty, your assistant

Lifty is HelpLift's AI assistant. Select the chat button in the corner of any page to open it. Ask how anything on HelpLift works, or ask about open needs, organizations, gift offerings and impact stories.

- Type a question, or select the microphone to speak it.
- Select the speaker button on a reply to hear it read aloud.
- Select the headphones to start a hands-free voice chat. Lifty listens, answers out loud, then listens again.
- Or turn on Hey Lifty in Settings. Then just say Hey Lifty: Lifty opens, greets you and listens for your question. A small green microphone on Lifty's button shows it is listening, which happens only while HelpLift is open and the chat is closed.
- Hide Lifty with the eye button, or turn it off and on again in Settings.

Lifty can only see public information. It cannot see your donations, messages or account details, and it will never ask for your password or banking details.

CHAPTER 10

Accessibility

- Themes: light, dark, high contrast and grayscale.
- Font size: larger text across the site.
- Speech to text: a microphone button on text boxes lets you speak instead of typing.
- Read aloud: listen to needs, gift offerings, stories, announcements and Lifty's replies.
- Grammar check: checks longer text before you submit it.
- Reduce motion and click sounds, in Settings.
- Install HelpLift as an app on your phone or computer from your browser's menu. HelpLift shows when you are offline.
- Tooltips: hover over or focus on a button to see what it does.

CHAPTER 11

Safety and privacy

HelpLift will never ask you to pay

- No fees: you never pay a fee to receive a donation, claim a gift, verify your account or unlock funds.
- No passwords or codes: HelpLift never asks for your password, PIN or a one-time code.
- No side payments: every payment happens through HelpLift's own donation flow, never by a bank transfer to an individual, a WhatsApp payment or a processing fee.

If anyone claiming to be from HelpLift asks you to pay upfront or share your login details, it is a scam. Report it using the contact form on the homepage with the topic Report a scam or safety concern.

Anonymous tip-offs

If you suspect a registered organization of fraud, misuse of donations, abuse, corruption or any other illegal or suspicious activity, select Anonymous tip-off in the safety section of the homepage.

1. Start typing the organization's name and pick it from the list, or type the name in full.
2. Choose what the concern is about and describe what happened, with as much detail as you safely can.
3. Optionally, say when it happened and attach evidence such as photos, documents or videos.
4. Leave a contact email only if you are happy for the HelpLift team to follow up, then send the tip-off.

Tip-offs are anonymous. HelpLift does not save your name, account, IP address or device, and the organization is never told that it was reported or by whom. The HelpLift team investigates every tip-off. If someone is in immediate danger, contact the police on 10111 first.

Your privacy

HelpLift follows the Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA). Public profiles never show donations or donors, and your contact details are not shared. HelpLift records sign-ins and activity on the platform for security, and keeps these records for a limited time. Read the Privacy Policy on the website for full details.

Keeping your account secure

- Use a strong password and do not share it.
- Turn on two-factor sign-in, or add a passkey.
- Sign out on shared devices.

CHAPTER 12

Getting help

- Ask Lifty: the chat button in the corner of every page.
- Frequently asked questions: on the homepage, with a search box and a full list.
- Anonymous tip-off: on the homepage, to report a registered organization for illegal or suspicious activity.
- Contact form: on the homepage. Choose a topic so your message reaches the right person.
- Message Admin: on your dashboard, to message the HelpLift team.
- Developers page: report a bug or suggest an improvement.
- Feedback: rate HelpLift from your dashboard.

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